

SBGP M/WBE Information Process Mapping

Final Report & Deliverables Summary

Client: South Baltimore Gateway Partnership (SBGP)

Project: MWBE Information Process Mapping

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Executive Summary

The South Baltimore Gateway Partnership (SBGP) engaged the University of Maryland iConsultancy team to evaluate and improve the organization's Minority- and Women-Owned Business Enterprise (M/WBE) compliance workflow. The primary goal of the project was to simplify the vendor submission pathway while maintaining compliance with the City of Baltimore's Minority and Women's Business Opportunity Office (MWBOO) requirements.

Throughout the engagement, the project team conducted stakeholder interviews, analyzed existing documentation and workflows, identified operational pain points, and developed a series of process improvement recommendations and vendor-facing resources.

Key findings revealed that the current workflow relied heavily on manual communication, lacked standardized onboarding processes, and created frequent revision cycles due to incomplete submissions and unclear guidance. Vendors often struggled to understand participation goals, documentation requirements, and directory search procedures, while internal staff experienced challenges with tracking submissions, coordinating reviews, and managing compliance documentation across long-term projects.

To address these challenges, the team developed:

- A documented "As-Is" workflow map representing the current compliance process
- An optimized "To-Be" workflow designed to reduce rework and improve communication
- A standardized M/WBE Compliance Submission Checklist
- A plain-language Vendor Compliance Guide
- An improved budget template with instructional guidance
- A Technical Tool Integration Plan outlining opportunities for automation, centralized tracking, and future CRM integration

These deliverables aim to improve vendor experience, reduce administrative burden, increase transparency across workflow stages, and support SBGP's long-term modernization goals.

1. Client Background & Project Goals

Organization Overview

The South Baltimore Gateway Partnership (SBGP) is a community-driven organization dedicated to improving neighborhoods within the South Baltimore Gateway District. SBGP supports initiatives related to economic development, environmental resilience, public services, and community revitalization.

As part of its commitment to equitable growth and compliance with City of Baltimore regulations, SBGP manages Minority- and Women-Owned Business Enterprise (M/WBE) participation requirements for funded projects and vendor contracts.

Project Need

SBGP identified several challenges associated with the current M/WBE compliance process:

- Complex and difficult-to-understand documentation
- Inconsistent communication with vendors and grantees
- Heavy reliance on manual tracking methods
- Multiple submission revision cycles
- Administrative bottlenecks between internal teams
- Limited workflow visibility and centralized tracking

The organization sought recommendations for creating a more streamlined, user-friendly, and transparent process for both vendors and staff.

Project Objectives

The project team was tasked with:

- Mapping the current end-to-end M/WBE compliance workflow
- Identifying operational inefficiencies and communication gaps
- Designing an optimized workflow process
- Creating vendor-facing resources and documentation
- Exploring opportunities for automation and centralized tracking
- Providing strategic recommendations for future implementation

2. Research & Discovery Process

Stakeholder Engagement

The team conducted multiple meetings with SBGP stakeholders, including:

- Initial client alignment meeting
- Operations Team workflow review meeting
- Program Team stakeholder interviews
- Follow-up project review and validation meetings

These meetings focused on:

- Understanding the current workflow
- Clarifying roles and responsibilities
- Identifying vendor pain points
- Reviewing internal documentation processes
- Evaluating opportunities for process improvement

Documentation Review

The project team reviewed and analyzed:

- Existing M/WBE compliance guidelines
- Budget templates
- Statement of Intent (SOI) tracking logs
- Payment verification logs
- Existing workflow diagrams
- MWBOO participation requirements

Key Themes Identified

Several recurring themes emerged throughout stakeholder interviews and documentation review:

Vendor Challenges

- Difficulty understanding compliance terminology
- Confusion regarding participation goals and exclusions
- Challenges navigating the MWBOO directory
- Limited understanding of required documentation
- Delayed communication during review cycles

Internal Staff Challenges

- Manual tracking across spreadsheets, emails, and SharePoint
- Inconsistent review procedures

- Lack of centralized workflow visibility
- Frequent revision cycles and rework
- Difficulty tracking long-term projects and compliance documentation

Communication Challenges

- Heavy reliance on email communication
 - Unclear handoff points between teams
 - Limited status transparency for vendors
 - Delays caused by fragmented communication
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3. Current State (“As-Is”) Workflow Findings

Overview

The current M/WBE compliance process involves multiple stakeholders and review stages, including vendors/grantees, Program Teams, Operations Teams, and the City of Baltimore’s MWBOO.

The workflow generally includes:

1. Planning and vendor preparation
2. Internal review and submission
3. MWBOO review and contract execution
4. Ongoing compliance monitoring
5. Final reporting and project closeout

Key Workflow Challenges

Lack of Standardized Onboarding

Vendors often begin the process without a consistent understanding of:

- Participation goals
- Required documents
- Search term expectations
- Submission procedures
- Timeline expectations

This creates confusion early in the workflow and contributes to incomplete submissions.

Multiple Revision Cycles

Stakeholders estimated that approximately 80% of submissions require revisions before approval.

Common causes include:

- Missing documentation
- Incorrect search terms
- Budget inconsistencies
- Invalid or incomplete SOIs
- Incomplete vendor outreach documentation

Manual Tracking & Communication

The current process relies heavily on:

- Email communication
- Spreadsheet tracking
- Manual status updates
- Shared documents across multiple platforms

This creates operational inefficiencies and limits workflow transparency.

Long-Term Compliance Tracking Challenges

Stakeholders identified ongoing monitoring as a significant pain point due to:

- Missing proof of payment documentation
- Inconsistent invoice tracking
- Delayed vendor follow-up
- Difficulty managing long-term projects

4. Optimized (“To-Be”) Workflow Design

Design Principles

The redesigned workflow was developed using the following guiding principles:

- Standardization across workflow stages
- Early validation to reduce downstream errors
- Reduced revision cycles and administrative rework
- Centralized communication and tracking
- Improved vendor onboarding and clarity

- Better alignment between Program and Operations teams

Major Workflow Improvements

Structured Onboarding

The optimized workflow introduces:

- Standardized onboarding sessions
- Clear submission timelines
- Simplified instructional resources
- Pre-filled templates and guidance materials

This helps vendors understand requirements earlier in the process.

Guided Submission Process

The redesigned process introduces:

- Checklist-driven submissions
- Structured forms or intake systems
- Built-in validation concepts
- Standardized documentation expectations

This reduces incomplete submissions and revision cycles.

Streamlined Internal Review

The optimized workflow creates:

- Defined review responsibilities
- Standardized review checkpoints
- Consolidated feedback procedures
- Clear handoff points between teams

This improves review consistency and reduces delays.

Centralized Tracking & Communication

The proposed future-state workflow includes:

- Shared status tracking
- Dashboard visibility
- Automated notifications
- Centralized documentation management

This improves transparency for both vendors and staff.

5. Deliverables Summary

5.1 “As-Is” Workflow Diagram

The project team developed a detailed workflow map documenting the current M/WBE compliance process.

The workflow diagram includes:

- Current workflow stages
- Stakeholder responsibilities
- Review loops and revision cycles
- Existing communication pathways
- Identified bottlenecks and inefficiencies

The workflow reflects stakeholder interviews and validation discussions conducted with both Program and Operations teams.

5.2 Optimized “To-Be” Workflow Diagram

The optimized workflow redesign introduces:

- Standardized onboarding
- Guided submissions
- Streamlined review stages
- Centralized communication recommendations
- Improved compliance tracking concepts

The redesign focuses on reducing confusion, minimizing manual rework, and improving transparency across workflow stages.

5.3 M/WBE Compliance Submission Checklist

The project team developed a vendor-facing checklist designed to simplify compliance preparation and submission.

The checklist includes:

- Step-by-step submission requirements
- Vendor outreach tracking guidance
- Documentation expectations

- Revision guidance
- Payment verification requirements
- Final closeout procedures

The checklist was revised based on direct client feedback to ensure alignment with current MWBOO requirements and operational procedures.

5.4 SBGP M/WBE Compliance Guide for Vendors

The project team redesigned the existing compliance guidance document into a more accessible, plain-language resource.

Key improvements include:

- Simplified explanations
- Step-by-step guidance
- Organized sections
- Definitions for key terminology
- Clarified vendor search expectations
- Timeline explanations
- Improved readability and usability

The redesigned guide is intended to reduce vendor confusion and minimize reliance on ad hoc staff explanations.

5.5 Budget Template Improvements

The project team redesigned and reorganized the existing budget template to improve usability and clarity.

Enhancements include:

- Instructional overview tab
- Quick-start guidance
- Clarified column descriptions
- Improved vendor search tracking structure
- Payment verification guidance
- Organized formatting and labeling

The redesigned template aims to reduce vendor errors and improve submission consistency.

5.6 Technical Tool Integration Plan

The team developed a Technical Tool Integration Plan exploring opportunities for workflow modernization and automation.

Recommendations include:

- Centralized submission tracking systems
- Automated notification workflows
- Shared dashboards and reporting visibility
- CRM integration considerations
- Workflow status tracking concepts

The plan also evaluates how current tools (such as Asana) and future systems (such as Salesforce CRM) could support the optimized workflow.

6. Technical Recommendations

Short-Term Recommendations

Improve Existing Asana Workflow Structure

Recommended improvements include:

- Standardized workflow stages
- Custom tracking fields
- Shared project templates
- Better task ownership visibility
- Centralized project documentation links

These improvements could provide immediate workflow visibility without requiring major system implementation.

Mid-Term Recommendations

Introduce Structured Intake & Tracking Systems

Potential solutions include:

- Microsoft Power Apps
- SharePoint-based submission tracking
- Power Automate workflows
- Shared status dashboards

These tools could help standardize submissions and reduce manual communication.

Long-Term Recommendations

Salesforce CRM Integration

As SBGP explores Salesforce implementation, the organization may benefit from:

- Centralized vendor records
- Automated workflow tracking
- Status dashboards
- Document management
- Automated reminders and notifications
- Compliance reporting features

The optimized workflow and standardized documentation created during this project are designed to support future CRM integration.

7. Future Recommendations & Next Steps

Vendor Experience Improvements

Recommended future initiatives include:

- Live onboarding sessions
- Recorded training materials
- Simplified FAQ resources
- Example submissions and templates
- Visual process walkthroughs

Internal Process Improvements

Recommended operational improvements include:

- Standardized review procedures
- Defined team responsibilities
- Shared workflow ownership
- Centralized communication tracking
- Consistent project milestone monitoring

Technology & Automation Opportunities

Potential future opportunities include:

- Automated submission validation
 - Integrated vendor portals
 - Dashboard reporting tools
 - Workflow notification systems
 - Compliance analytics and reporting
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8. Conclusion

The SBGP MWBE Information Process Mapping project provided an opportunity to evaluate and redesign a complex compliance workflow through a user-centered and operationally focused lens.

Through stakeholder interviews, workflow analysis, documentation review, and collaborative design, the project team identified opportunities to improve vendor experience, reduce administrative burden, and support long-term process modernization.

The final deliverables developed throughout this engagement aim to:

- Simplify vendor onboarding and compliance preparation
- Improve workflow transparency and communication
- Reduce revision cycles and manual tracking burdens
- Support more standardized internal processes
- Prepare SBGP for future automation and CRM integration opportunities

The team hopes these recommendations and resources will support SBGP's continued commitment to equitable development, operational efficiency, and improved stakeholder experience.

Appendix

Included Deliverables

- Current "As-Is" MWBE Compliance Workflow
 - Current "As-Is" MWBE Compliance Workflow Chart
- Optimized "To-Be" Workflow Diagram
 - Optimized "To-Be" Workflow Diagram Chart
- M/WBE Compliance Submission Checklist
- SBGP M/WBE Compliance Guide for Vendors

- Improved Budget Template
- Technical Tool Integration Plan
- Meeting Agendas & Stakeholder Notes
- Presentation Slides

Design File Access

Some deliverables include visual assets created using external design platforms such as Canva.

Editable template links:

- [Current M/WBE Compliance Workflow](#)
- [Optimized M/WBE Compliance Workflow](#)
- [SBGP M/WBE Compliance Guide](#)